

rode horses. We drove around the Smoky Mountains, went fishing, and visited Dollywood's best problematic attraction, the Dixie Stampede. And for the most part, everyone around us was on the same playing field.

When I was in second grade, my dad's alcoholism launched my mom into a journey for deeper meaning. She started attending synagogue regularly, found her own friends, and, most important, found her higher purpose. She became increasingly observant. I remember her inviting the rabbi and his wife over to help us turn our entire kitchen kosher. This meant replacing all the dishes and silverware and purchasing two different sets, which we ended up using for years—one white for dairy and one black for meat. It was an expensive and arduous undertaking.

All the other people at the synagogue sent their children to strict Jewish schools, so she switched me out of public school. We'd be paying tuition now. We started associating with different kinds of people.

At my public school, my best friend had been a girl named Madeline who lived in a small duplex with her family. Her parents were Tai Kwon Do instructors. One year for Halloween, she dressed up as a car crash victim, meaning her parents wrapped her in gauze, toilet paper, and red paint. They weren't wealthy either.

At my new all-Jewish school, the majority of the students were upper middle to upper class. That was the first time I realized I was in a somewhat lower economic bracket. For one thing, when I started there, my family still lived in the town of Hollywood, which was very un-PCly nicknamed "Hollyhood." My new school, however, had been built alongside a nicer neighborhood's Jewish Community Center so we could use its new sports facilities and big playgrounds. The school was surrounded by a thick black fence, and security guards stood at all the entrances.

Because of school uniforms, I skated by without fully realizing I was poorer than my new friends until middle school. When bar and bat mitzvah season descended, the ruse got cracked wide open. Every weekend, another kid in my grade had a huge party celebrating the transition into "adulthood." Sometimes there were even multiple parties a weekend. (More on that insanity in Chapter 12 on weddings.)